Documentary Day 1: *Remembering Curiosity*

Today we're starting the journey toward making your own documentary. But not by filming yet. First, you're going to practice **noticing** things — because documentaries start with curiosity, not cameras.

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1. What's a Documentary Really About?

A documentary doesn't start with facts. It starts with **a question** someone actually cares about. Someone notices something, can't stop thinking about it, and decides to look closer.

We're going to practice that kind of noticing.

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2. The Memory Timeline

You're going to make a quick list of things you *remember* — not big life events (although it can be), just things that stuck with you. Good rule of thumb: if it immediately jumps into your mind, don't think or judge for a second and just write it down.

Draw this on a paper:

Time	Two memories that come to mind
Today:	
This week:	
This month:	
This year:	
My life so far:	
Something you know you'll notice about:	
Today:	
This year:	
The rest of your life:	

Examples:
- The quiet hallway before class
- My friend acting weird at lunch
- The soccer game that got rained out
- A trip that went wrong
- My first pet

If you remember it, it's probably because it was **good, bad, surprising, or unusual.**

3. From Memory to Question — Building the Bridge

Now you're going to pick one thing on your list and work it into a question. Here's how:

Step 1. Describe it again

Pick one memory. Describe it out loud or on paper for 30 seconds.

- What did you see, hear, or feel?
- Who was there or not there?
- What happened right before or after?

Step 2. Find the weird or interesting part

Ask yourself:

- What made this moment stick with me?
- What's the most interesting or strange thing about it?

Examples:

- "The hallway was empty. It felt creepy."
- "My friend seemed off but wouldn't say why."
- "It was raining, but we kept playing."

Step 3. Turn that into a question

Now that you know what felt strange or interesting, try turning it into a question:

- Why does empty space feel creepy?
- What happens when a place that's usually loud goes quiet?
- Why do people keep playing when they know they'll lose?
- Why do I like quiet more than I thought?

Use these question starters if you get stuck:

- Why does...
- What does it feel like when...
- What happens when...
- How do people deal with...
- What do I not understand about...

4. Pair Up

Share one memory with a partner. Ask each other:

- What's interesting about that?
- What do you want to know more about?
- What could we see that connects to it?

You'll probably notice your partner's questions help you find your own. That's how documentaries often start — in conversation.

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5. Visual Thinking

Once you have a question that feels alive, list 4–5 things you could ***film*** to explore it.

Example:

Core Question: *Why do my friends always sit in the same spot?*
Footage: the table, the empty hallway, laughter, silence, friends faces, cafeteria, school building, camp pictures, someone sitting and standing, etc..

You're not filming yet. You're just learning to see what your question ***might look*** like.

Today's takeaway:
A documentary begins when you notice something, wonder about it, and stay with that feeling long enough to ask *why.*